

ation that they may have overlap in responsibilities with or are dependent on in their workflow

Our Simone (Software Engineer in Test) is a good example of many of these.

Not all of the additional details are necessary, so it can be helpful to discuss with stakeholders to know which could be useful. If there is any doubt, a guideline is the more detailed, the better.

Steps for building out a user persona

The process for building out user personas is based on data obtained through user research. The following steps are designed to provide teams with the data they need to build out a new user persona with a high degree of confidence and accuracy.

It's strongly recommended to consult with a UX Researcher at the start and conclusion of each step. This will help set you up for success as you start efforts and also provide you with another set of eyes to review your data.

Step 1: Meet with Stakeholders

Stakeholders are team members who are likely to use this user persona in the process of their own work. Ideal team members would typically be Software Engineers, Product Managers, Product Designers, and so on, who have experience with tools for the persona you are trying to build. For example, if you are building a persona for a security analyst then your stakeholders should have experience with building security tools for those users.

The goal of this step is to increase our understanding of what information is most important to ask in the interviews and which information to use in the screeners to collect participants.

1. Create a research issue for problem validation, and fill in the template to the best of your ability.

1. Then, use the User Persona - Stakeholder conversation [Template] and fill in the information for your own persona.

1. Place a link to this sheet in your issue.

1. Write down a list of the stakeholders you want feedback from for this persona. This should be ideally 5 team members who would interact with this persona and have some knowledge of the users in question. Ask your stakeholders to fill out their own section of your User Persona Stakeholder Conversation sheet.

1. If you are one of the stakeholders for this project, try not to contribute very much in this phase, and let your other stakeholders steer most of the insights.

1. When filling out the sheet, consider different use cases, tools, job responsibilities, or anything else that the potential persona has to face in their job that could impact their interaction with GitLab.

1. When all stakeholders have filled out the information, summarize their feedback in the 'summary' tab of the Google Sheet and write the results in your research issue.

Step 2: Internal Interviews

The second step is to interview between 5-10 GitLab team members who have the same or a similar job title to the user persona being created. This meeting should be approx. 30 min, but you may want to allow more time if you need more information.

The goal of this step is to expand on the information already gathered and to interact directly with the population you are trying to understand, which will help us know that we are asking the right participants the correct questions.

To conduct these interviews:

1. Create a new research issue for tracking your interviews and results.
 1. Use the User Persona - Internal Stakeholder Script [Google Docs Template] and fill in the title and details with your persona.
 1. Link your Google Sheet in your issue.
1. Use the GitLab team page, various department team pages (like the Engineering page), or put a message in a team's slack channel (usually found near the bottom of a team page) to recruit internal participants for feedback.
 1. Use a Calendly link to schedule the 30 minute interview sessions.
1. During each interview session:
 1. If you need to take notes, or have an additional note taker, use the user interview notes template.
1. Summarize the interview data question by question to look for trends. Use the Persona - Screener Questions template to help guide what to look for.
1. Document the summarized insights (including your screener questions) in the research issue, and ask stakeholders to review your data.
 1. Note whether any trends are different from what your stakeholders expected based on the previous research you conducted Step 1. If there are differences, then try to understand what assumptions were made and how to correct them.

Step 3: Validate user personas with users in the wider GitLab community

This is a critical step! The purpose of this step is to validate and prioritize the characteristics derived from our internal interviews and to establish the differences between our expectations and real-world findings.

These moderated interviews should take approximately 1 hour. Recruit 8-10 participants for a given persona, focusing on participants who reflect the general makeup of the market. The goal of these interviews is to connect with our users and fill out the framework of our user persona with real user data.

A) Recruit & schedule participants

To kick off participant recruitment, refer to the UX handbook guide on how to recruit and schedule participants. Open a recruitment issue and use the screener derived from your previous research Step 2. Use the handbook page on writing screener questions for help, if needed.

B) Create Interview Script

Use the summarized information created from Step 1 and [Step 2 to craft the script for the external interviews. The first section of the script should focus on the top jobs of the persona, and the motivations and frustrations of those jobs.

If you are unfamiliar on GitLab's JTBD, here is a small overview and guide

1. The user's objectives
1. The tools and materials they use
1. Understanding how they are evaluated on their job's success

Later sections of the script may vary depending on what your past research indicates as important to the persona. You will most likely want to ask questions about key tools your persona uses, any areas of GitLab they use or have trouble in, or other teams that provide essential work to your persona.

C) Conduct interviews

After enough participants have been recruited and scheduled, it is time to conduct the interviews! To prepare for these interviews, be sure to understand GitLab's handbook page on how to facilitate a user interview. More help can also be found in our discussion guide template.

To help streamline data intake during interviews, you may use this Persona Interview template (Google Form) as a script and tool to fill in participant responses.

To conduct these interviews:

1. Create a new research issue for tracking your interviews and results.
 1. Use the User Persona - External Interviews Script (Google Form template) with your data from previous research. Use the form element as a method to read your script while recording the participant's responses.
 1. Link your Google Sheet in your issue.
1. During each interview session:
 1. Record the participant's name and job title, and job description, and then read each question out loud, recording their answers in the form.
 1. If you need to take notes, or have an additional note taker, use the user interview notes template.
1. Summarize the data in the Response tab of your Google Form, or export the data to a Google Sheet using the sheets export button.
 1. Document the summarized insights (including your screener questions) in the research issue, and ask stakeholders to review your data.

Step 4: Synthesize & Compare Results

A) Synthesize the user data

If you are using the Google Form template as described above, then the data synthesis will be a similar process for each round of research. If you need more help codifying the results, this handbook article on data synthesis may help.

For all open-ended questions, you first have to transform the qualitative data into something easier to understand. Do this by clustering responses into themes and tallying the counts of all themes. An example of this can be found in the table below:

Participant's answer	Question asked	Themes
:-----: :-----: :-----:		
-----:		

| What obstacles do you face when trying to accomplish the goals for your job? | Sometimes when I don't see that a coworker has sent a merge request, it can take a while for me to approve it.
| Missed communication |

For all close-ended questions, document the number of times each answer was given across all participants for each question to identify trends.

Once you have all answers counted, look at how many participants answered each question and evaluate the data for any trends. There are no set rules for this analysis, but some trends to look for include:

Trend to look for	Example
----- -----	

50% or more of participants selecting a small handful of answers	Answer A: 60% Answer B: 20% Answer C: 10% Answer D: 10%
A large drop off in certain answers compared to others	Answer A: 40% Answer B: 40% Answer C: 10% Answer D: 10%

B) Compare Results

As you summarize each round of research, you can compare the answers from the previous participants to the most recent participants. If you see unexpected results, try to understand the reason for the differences and incorporate those into your final insights.

Step 5: Publish the new persona through a merge request

When all of the data has been collected and summarized, it's time to update the Roles & Personas handbook page.

Copy the text from one of the already existing user personas, and paste it below the last persona that is currently filled out. Edit the information for the persona you have collected data on, and double check all of the information, including the name and title of the persona.

Assign the merge request to one of the managers found in the 'Maintained By' section on the same Roles & Personas page.

Keeping user personas up to date

The most common ways that personas become misaligned is when there is a business or technology change, or when there is a change to the user base. This helpful Nielsen Norman Group article goes into more detail on both of these if you are unsure on the difference or how to recognize them.

If stakeholders believe that a particular user persona no longer provides the information that it needs to, or if market data is indicating a change that impacts a persona, then it's time to update an existing persona or create a new one.

Combining two or more personas

Personas that were originally independent from one another may become less distinct over time, either due to changes in roles or job duties. When stakeholders believe there are overlaps between two or more personas, there are some steps to follow prior to making a change.

1. Stakeholders should collect all known information about the personas in question. For example, this can include interviews with customers or previously researched JTBD statements on a specific persona.

1. All existing data about the personas should be mapped out, so that stakeholders can visualize all of the information at once. One way to assess the amount of overlap between personas is a Venn diagram.

1. There are some general guidelines to follow when creating your Venn diagram:

1. If the number of bullet points (i.e., number of jobs to be done, motivations, and frustrations combined) that are similar between the personas in question are greater than the number of bullet points that are different, personas could be consolidated.

1. If the number of bullet points that are similar between the personas in question are equal to the number of bullet points that are different, a new persona could be created.

1. If the number of bullet points that are similar between the personas in question are less than the number of bullet points that are different, personas could be left unchanged.

1. Based on the mapping exercise, stakeholders should consult with UX Research on the outcome of this mapping exercise to determine which direction to proceed (i.e., whether to combine existing personas together, leave personas as is, or create a new persona).

Frequently Asked Questions

How many personas should be used within a company? How many is too many?

There is no "correct" number of personas that a company should have. In general, personas should be distinct enough from one another, so that one persona is not easily mistaken for another. The more personas you have, the greater the chance that team members will not remember distinct information about them. A simple way to determine the number of personas within a company is to identify the most important user groups that you want to target with your product and create personas based on those groups.

Is a broader persona better or worse than a detailed one?

Personas should be detailed enough that they can be believable, but should be broad enough to represent specific types of user groups. The level of detail desired for personas will depend on the goal of the effort. Ideally, personas should be detailed enough to at least cover each of their goals, motivations, and frustrations.

When should personas be considered outdated? How often should personas be updated?

Personas should be evaluated over time to assess whether they represent the main types of users that were originally identified. Personas are seen as snapshots in time, so they can become outdated if you fail to consider changes in the business, marketplace, and demographics about your users. If you examine those factors and determine that there are differences between your data and current personas, additional research could be needed before you commit to update personas. If you need advice on potential research for personas, please consult with UX research for assistance.

There is no correct frequency for when to update personas, but companies should take into account time and resources needed to update personas (in addition to factors discussed above). Also, it is important to consider how much the product or user experience has changed since the persona was last researched. Generally, personas that have been stagnant for about 5 or more years might not be as valid as personas that are more up-to-date.

How much time should be spent to create personas?

External research looked into the amount of time that employees at large (more than 500 employees) organizations spent on creating user personas. Overall, there were differences in the amount of time it took to create personas when using non-empirical data (leveraging past data or knowledge about a user population) compared to empirical data (utilizing research efforts to learn about a user population). For projects that used non-empirical data, the amount of time needed to create personas was approximately 55 hours. For projects focused on obtaining empirical data, large companies needed approximately 102.5 hours to create personas.

SECTION: product/ux/product-design/_index.md

Role of Product Designers

Product Designers are assigned to a specific area of the product, known as Stage Groups, where they immerse themselves in user workflows to solve real customer problems.

They are also responsible for broader UX department efforts, such as:

- Supporting community contributions
- Contributing to the Pajamas Design System
- Reviewing other designers' work

Each designer works as a manager of one to solve customers problems and align with the direction of the product. They collaborate with stage peers and managers to manage their capacity and deliver results on time. For a detailed view into how Product Designers work, review the Product Designer workflow page.

For more information on Stage Groups, team member assignments, and product direction, visit the product category page.

Process and Design Responsibility

Owner of design judgment

As Product Designers, we are entrusted with the authority of design judgment. Our process begins with understanding the problem and prioritizing for the best user experience. When additional constraints or insights (e.g. technical considerations or marketing strategies) arise, we collaboratively evaluate and adjust our designs accordingly. We proactively communicate how these constraints impact our designs and what changes will affect the user.

In cases where our counterparts have differing opinions, we consider their perspectives but hold the final say on design decisions as we are the ultimate guardians of design judgment.

Design Principles and Tools

Our design principles are outlined in the Pajamas Design System.

Product Designer Tools

- UX Scorecard
- Category Maturity Scorecard
- UX Issue Triage
- Heuristics
- Competitor Evaluation (GitLab Team Member access only)
- UX Cloud Sandbox

Figma and Figjam are our primary design tool of choice. Refer to the usage and access details.

Product Design Workflow

Product Designers adhere to the Product Development flow in collaboration with stable counterparts. Key aspects include:

- Planning and managing capacity
- Prioritization
- Working on Issues
- Design Process
- Partnering with UX Research
- Partnering with Technical Writers
- Contributing to Pajamas
- Designing with AI

New GitLab Product Designers should refer to the Product Designer Workflow handbook page for a comprehensive guide to getting started.

Product Design Management Workflow

- Product Design Manager Workflows
- Product Design Manager Pairs

Learning and Development

Our continuous learning initiatives are documented in the UX Department Learning and Development section.

SECTION: product/ux/product-design/design-studios.md

Design Studios

Design Studios (or just Studios) are regular meetings for product designers to connect and work together. These meetings aren't limited to specific teams - any product designer can join.

They provide casual time for socializing, sharing work, getting feedback, and more. They help fill the gap between async and larger sync meetings. With just a few designers meeting together, we can build better personal and work relationships. This should also help us work better together outside these meetings.

To track issues related to these meetings, use the Design studios label.

Background

After a successful first pilot for designers in EMEA time zones, we expanded to more time zones with several volunteer hosts. We even had an in-person Studio at Summit 2024! We learned a lot and wrote this guide so everyone could learn about them. For more details, see the 2024-02-21 UX Showcase: recording and slides.

Who can join

Studios are only for Product Design individual contributors (not managers). They're meant to be a safe space where we only share materials with other product designers. We discussed including managers but were worried that fewer people would participate. Hosts are responsible for sharing relevant discussions more widely while keeping people anonymous when needed. See issues related to the Studios.

How to join

As a product designer, your attendance is optional, but Studios work better when more people join, so please come if you can!

You're invited to all available Design Studios - choose the one that work best for you. They're also on the UX calendar.

Start a new Studio

Want to help start a new Studio? Great! Thanks for your interest.

Before adding a new Studio, please contact us to discuss the need for a new Studio and ways to make it successful.

<details>

<summary>Steps to start a new Studio</summary>

Follow these steps after getting approval:

1. Set up agenda:
 1. Duplicate template.
 1. Follow instructions in the template.
1. Create Zoom meeting:
 1. Open Zoom app and select Meetings from the top bar.
 1. On the left sidebar, select the  icon to schedule a meeting.
 1. Set the topic to  Design studio <YOURSTUDIONUMBER>. Replace <YOURSTUDIONUMBER> based on the scheduling order of the other Studios (check your calendar or the UX calendar). This follows the multi-session meeting naming.
 1. Set date, time, and 50-minute duration.
 1. Make it weekly with no end date.
 1. Leave attendees empty (they'll be added in calendar).
 1. Security: Enable passcode, disable waiting room, select "GitLab Internal Only" in Only authenticated users can join.
 1. Under Calendar, select "Other Calendars", as you'll add the meeting URL the calendar invite.
 1. Advanced Options: Allow participants to join anytime, add any co-hosts.
 1. Save and copy your Zoom link (screenshot).
1. Set up calendar event:
 1. In the UX calendar, open an existing Studio event.
 1. Select the  icon, and then Duplicate.
 1. Update the Studio number in the title
 1. Set the same weekday and time as your Zoom meeting.
 1. Set to repeat weekly.
 1. In the Location, add your Zoom link you got in the previous step.
 1. The guest list should already include all product designers.
 1. To attach your new agenda document, remove the existing attachment and then select the Google Drive icon.
 1. Save!

What next?

1. Announce the new Studio in the ux and uxcoworking Slack channels.
1. Another host will try to join your first session to provide support.
1. Check the feedback survey responses.

</details>

Measure success

We measure success in two main ways:

1. Anytime: Attendees can give feedback through the anonymous survey shared on every call.
1. Quarterly review: We look more closely at several aspects:
 1. We encourage attendees to complete the anonymous feedback survey, and we then review their responses.
 1. Attendees can join a retrospective discussion. See all retrospective issues.
 1. We report attendee satisfaction and attendance numbers in the retrospective issue.

Contact

For questions or suggestions, contact a maintainer listed on the right side of this page.

SECTION: product/ux/product-design/hiring-product-designers.md

Hiring process

Product Designers follow the Hiring & Talent Acquisition process.

General resources:

- Interviewing at GitLab
- Product Designer job family

Interviews for Product Designers

Each Product Designer candidate is interviewed by a panel of interviewers that include:

- Product Designer
- Product Design Manager
- Senior Manager of Product Design
- Product Manager, Engineering Manager

A detailed description of each stage of our interview process is available along with the job description.

We have established a set of questions we ask at each stage of the process. All questions are available in the Greenhouse scorecard for the candidate. We ask the same questions to every candidate to ensure fairness--during the interview and when evaluating each candidate.

An interview rubric has been defined that provides a set of positive answer traits and characteristics to look out for when asking each of the Greenhouse interview questions. It's recommended that you:

1. Open the appropriate GDoc version for your interview level (i.e. Senior or Intermediate candidate) for quick access after your interview to aid in completing your Greenhouse Scorecard.

1. Compare your notes with the rubric on each question and

1. Assess how the candidate's answer compares to the desired positive traits/characteristics provided.

Use this rubric comparison/assessment to help with your final scorecard assessment prior to your scorecard submission.

Interview rubrics

1. Product Designer (peer) interview - Senior Candidate Rubric

1. Product Designer (peer) interview - Intermediate Candidate Rubric

1. Manager interview - Senior Candidate Rubric

1. Manager interview - Intermediate Candidate Rubric

Interview training

Any Product Designer can participate in the hiring process after completing the company interview training and a Product Design-specific interview training. These trainings will teach you how to perform successful interviews at GitLab.

In the last steps of the training, you will:

- Shadow an experienced Product Designer interviewer in two separate interviews, so that you can see how a successful interview is conducted.
- Be shadowed by your coach in two separate interviews. They will act as your coach and provide feedback on your interviewing skills.

You may request additional shadow opportunities, if you'd like additional practice and support.

Scorecard completion tips

Everyone who interviews a candidate must complete a scorecard and is required to input pros and cons as well as an overall recommendation.

Interview scorecards

- Talent Acquisition Process: Hiring team to complete feedback in Greenhouse

Tips for completing interview scorecards

- Enter your notes into each of the text areas provided in the candidate's Greenhouse Scorecard.
- Clean up any typos, misspellings, or incomplete statements as desired to aid the hiring manager's review process.
- Review the notes of the candidate's answers against the appropriate Rubric document and consider how their answers compared to it.
- Add your assessment of the candidate in the Pros/Cons sections of the Greenhouse Scorecard.
- Complete your assessment of the candidate's Attributes, only providing an assessment of the attributes that were discussed, and were available on their resume/CV, or portfolio. If an assessment didn't come, leave it unanswered.

Manager resources

Reference scorecards

- Talent Acquisition Process: Complete references

Justification scorecards

Tips for completing justification scorecards

This Justification should provide a summary of all the submitted Scorecards while incorporating

any additional commentary around how the hiring manager plans on helping the candidate be successful.

1. In what specific way(s) does this candidate make the team better?

1. Consider how the candidate meets each of the Must Have's and Nice-to-Have's outlined in the recruiting kickoff issue.

1. List and explain any other strengths and/or unique skills the candidate brings to the role and team.

1. What flags were raised during the interview process?

1. Consider how the candidate doesn't meet some of the Must Have's and Nice-to-Have's outlined in the recruiting kickoff issue and explain your reasoning for moving forward, and how you will address them.

1. Consider any concerns raised during the interviews and explain your reasoning for moving forward, and how you will address them.

1. How do we intend on setting this candidate up for success?

1. Consider the candidate's soft skills and values, how will you help them progress and succeed at GitLab?

1. Consider the above "raised flags" and explain how you're going to help set the candidate up for success, helping them to overcome these or any weaknesses they may have.

1. Is the offer in-plan, and why? E.g. it is a critical budgeted hire, backfill, or transfer.

1. Provide the correct answer. If you're unsure, work with your manager to determine the correct answer.

1. Does the candidate meet a simple majority of nice-to-have requirements (5 of 9) for the role?

1. Review the Nice-to-have attributes across the scorecards and provide the answer.

1. Attributes

1. Answer these based on a sum of all the scorecards submitted. For example, if they got 4 stars and one thumbs-up on the Collaboration value from the scorecards, pick the star to summarize that feedback. You do not need to leave notes.

SECTION: product/ux/product-design/product-design-manager.md

Requesting a borrow

A borrow is used when a team member is shifted from one team to another temporarily or assisting other teams part-time for an agreed-upon period of time.

There are two Borrow request options. Choose the one that makes the most sense for your situation.

- If multiple members (within or including outside of UX) are part of the borrow request, use the Borrow issue template.

- If a borrow is limited to a single member of UX (such as a Product Designer) and no other stable counterparts, use the Borrow Lite issue template.

Before a borrow takes place, make sure to have it approved by the appropriate director (Product Design, UX Research, or Technical Writing).

Utilizing these issues will help us understand the frequency and duration of borrows throughout the year. Tracking occurs by appending the UX Borrow label to each issue request.

Team Skills Matrix

We conduct an annual team skills analysis based on a process recommended by Nielsen-Norman.

The primary goal of the skills analysis is to inform individual team member's growth plans. Secondary benefits are that it allows us to see our strengths as a team, helps to identify team trainings that would benefit a large portion of the team, helps us identify strengths we'd like to add when hiring new team members and can also act as a resource for matching mentors and/or design pairs.

How to conduct the team assessment

1. Make a copy of the GitLab Team Skills Matrix (private to GitLab).
1. Review the template to make sure it makes sense for your team. Do consider changes carefully and discuss with other managers. We want to be able to have consistency so we can view them across multiple design teams.
1. Add your team members names to the spreadsheet.
1. Introduce this process to your team by sharing this page, the NN article and the GitLab focused template.
1. Ask team members to rate themselves (current and future state).
1. Review with your team member. You may suggest adjustments based on your observations, but ultimately this is a self-assessment.
1. Share the results in an issue -Example Issue.
1. To follow up on the results, the team members and their manager can identify opportunities to fill gaps where team members said they want to improve.
1. Repeat in Q1 on a yearly cadence.

Team Member Updates

Whenever you need to update the area of the product a team member is supporting, such as on the Product Categories page, you'll generally need to update or review the following pages and projects. For all updates you'll want to confirm that the name matches the name used on the team page.

Section-level updates

For section-level updates you'll want to do the following:

1. Go to the www.gitlab.com project > Repository > Files
1. Select the data directory
1. Scroll down and click on the sections.yml file
1. Select the editor type of your choice
1. Locate the person you need to update, make the change, commit/create an MR, and follow the MR process from there

Group-level updates

For group-level updates you'll want to do the following:

1. Go to the `www-gitlab-com` project > Repository > Files
1. Select the `data` directory
1. Scroll down and click on the `stages.yml` file
1. Select the editor type of your choice
1. Locate the person you need to update, make the change, commit/create an MR, and follow the MR process from there

Update Team Member (Such as to remove/add from UX MR Reviewer Roulette)

Go to the `www-gitlab-com` project > Repository > Files - Documentation

1. Navigate to the `data/teammembers/person/product` directory
1. Locate the correct alphabet letter folder according to the team members first initial in their first name
1. Click on their `.yml` file
1. Select the editor type of your choice
1. To remove from the UX MR Reviewer Roulette bot:
 1. Delete the `gitlab: reviewer UX` line under the `projects:` section
 1. Commit/create an MR, and follow the MR process from there
1. To add to the UX MR Reviewer Roulette bot:
 1. Revert the original MR where the team member was removed or
 1. Find their `.yml` file again following the above steps
 1. Add back the `gitlab: reviewer UX` line under the `projects:` section
 1. Commit/create an MR, and follow the MR process from there

Triage reports

In the `triage-ops` project, open an MR to add or remove team members from receiving triage reports. The file to edit is `groupdefinition.yml`.

Retrospectives

In the GitLab team retrospective group, find the team members section and group, and add and remove team members there. This step is required so that confidential issues can be seen by team members.

Also, open an MR to add or remove team members in the `team.yml` file in `async-retrospectives`.

Growth & Development

When working with your team members on any Growth & Development requests, please refer to the Growth and Development Benefit guidelines.

SECTION: `product/ux/product-design/ux-roadmaps/_index.md`

Overview

Neilsen Norman Group UX Roadmap guide and the Neilsen Norman Group UX Theme guide are prerequisites for understanding the overall purpose of this process. The documentation that follows discusses the differences in process and structure between the Nielsen Norman Group's documentation for UX Themes and GitLab.

UX Themes are comprehensive bundles of work organized around the user problem, their need, and their desired outcome. UX Themes comprise a team's UX Roadmap, which should act as a single source of truth for a team's North Star UX vision serving as the blueprint for their strategy. In essence, themes are a wrapper that looks at all the individual issues a Group may have and organizes them into relational bundles, allowing solutions to be holistic and non-fragmented. A UX Roadmap is simply the prioritization of these UX Themes based on user and business needs while also considering your team's confidence in the supporting data.

Benefits of UX Themes

Expanded stage alignment

UX Themes align across groups and stages, achieving a better understanding of the work done through their problems to solve and expected outcomes. They can help identify areas of collaboration when teams are working on overlapping user needs or when needs cross workflows helping to unite stable counterparts, engineering, design, product, and research with a comprehensive approach to executing the category vision.

Increased focus and decreased churn

UX Themes focus on a more significant, holistic problem area rather than discrete features in a milestone. This has the effect of reducing the need for fire drills and mitigating context switching. This focus will allow designers to dive deep into related needs-based problems that lead to a comprehensive experience, including all associated touchpoints in the product. Additionally, helping to allocate more time toward addressing validated user needs with solutions rather than assumptions will reduce design and research churn in the product development process. This approach also benefits the engineering teams as they can focus their efforts and build to the scope envisioned in the theme while reducing context switching and avoiding the need to refactor the code in the event of a redesign.

Enhanced strategic collaboration

UX Themes influence strategy through collaboration with Product Managers to define the goals, identify and prioritize unmet user needs, and transparently maintain and update the product roadmap over time. Themes also allow us to understand our value as a team by measuring our success against the business outcomes our counterparts define for each theme.

Roadmaps and UX Themes

UX Themes organized by priority become a UX Roadmap. This roadmap complements the product roadmap and does not replace or supersede them. Therefore, it's helpful to think of a UX Roadmap as a view of the Product roadmap through the filter of Product Design and UX Research.

<!-- Roadmap graphic to illustrate how a UXrm fits into the overall Product roadmap -->

Components of a UX Theme

UX Theme scope

UX Themes exist at the workflow level, addressing one or more of the user's small jobs they need to complete to satisfy their main JTBD. Typically, the theme's focus is a single small job, a step that rolls up to the main JTBD, which includes all the micro-jobs (tasks) a user will need to complete to satisfy the small job itself.

Addressing the small job this way adds depth to the experience. Alternatively, you can widen the scope of the UX Theme by considering multiple steps, or small jobs, of the main job, thus adding value to the breadth and depth of the experience. See the image below for a breakdown of these concepts.

Using JTBD to define and drive your work through their incorporation of UX Themes is, by design, what JTBD are intended to achieve. UX Themes are practical applications for JTBD, ensuring their usage across the organization.

JTBD and UX Themes:

<!-- Job map and UX Theme scope examples -->

The work done on a theme should keep the scope of the deliverables in mind. If the design cannot be implemented within a reasonable timeframe, then the scope of the theme is likely too large and should be reduced. A good guideline is three milestones to implement a UX Theme; One MVC: (feature: addition) followed by two (feature:enhancements) iterations to successfully implement the designs consecutively. There may be instances where a theme will take fewer iterations or even more if it is a more significant back-end change. It is also recommended to complete the entire UX Theme in consecutive milestones. Skipping theme completion or putting future iterations in a backlog should be avoided and should only be done when there is no other option to do so. In all cases, it is recommended to collaborate with your team's stable counterparts to reach a viable solution that continues to deliver value.

UX Theme structure

Theme component	Description	Example
Theme statement	Design objective	Reduce the effort for security teams when prioritizing business-critical risks in their assets.
Main JTBD	The JTBD that contains the task(s) a user will be undertaking.	When I am on triage rotation, I want to address all the business-critical risks in my assets, so I can minimize the likelihood of my organization being compromised by a security breach.
Business objective	Objectives (from a business point of view) that will be achieved upon completion.	Increase engagement by making the experience efficient while reducing the chances of users overlooking high-priority items.
Confidence	Informal assessments of likely impact and demonstrated user need for the theme.	High
Requirements	Considerations to keep in mind when working on the theme.	Related feature

issues, Research insights |

| Timeframe | The expected time period of a theme | Now: {Next:1-3 milestones} |

Theme statements

A theme statement combines the beneficiary, their job, and their expected outcome when the work is delivered and serves as the design goal for the team who owns the theme. Well-defined statements are concise without sacrificing the substance of the theme so that anyone can understand it at a glance.

A theme statement's structure should align to: (Outcome + Beneficiary + Small Job). Following this pattern will ensure you are creating outcome-based themes that are user-centric and jobs oriented.

| Statement components | Definition | Example |

| --- | --- | --- |

| Beneficiary | End-users who are the direct recipient of the value the theme is focused on. | Security teams |

| Small Job | A step of the larger job (Step(s) + object + qualifier) | Prioritize business-critical risks |

| Outcome | The user need the theme is addressing | Reduced effort across all assets |

For our example, the theme statement would be: Reduce the effort for security teams when prioritizing business-critical risks in their assets.

Note: The theme statement is the defacto title used to reference the theme and serves as the theme issue title.

Beneficiary

Beneficiaries are the end-users who are the direct recipient of the value the theme is delivering. Beneficiaries should be referenced by their role, for example, Software Developers. However, there may be some instances where the beneficiaries are not a single end-user but rather a group of similar end-users. In these cases, they can be called teams, for example, Software Development Teams or Security Teams.

Small Job

The small job(s) that is the theme's focus and a step of the larger JTBD. This is articulated by following the pattern (Verb + Object + Qualifier). For our example, The small job would be: Verb {Prioritize}, + Object {Risks}, + Qualifier {Business-critical}.

Outcome

Addressing the user's needs is the primary objective of the theme. Needs are informed by research and ladder up to the main JTBD. In our example, the primary JTBD need is to minimize the likelihood of my organization being compromised by a security breach. One way to help users achieve this is by reducing users' efforts to prioritize vulnerabilities.

Main JTBD

The main JTBD of the performer who will benefit from this UX Theme, typically your stage or stage: group's main JTBD. Including this information at the UX Theme level is necessary to ensure our focus remains on the main JTBD while working on the theme. In our example, our main JTBD is; When I am on triage rotation, I want to address all the business-critical risks in my assets, so I can minimize the likelihood of my organization being compromised by a security breach.

Note: If there is no JTBD or the JTBD is assumptive, that should indicate that you are working on a low-confidence theme and additional research is required before engaging in design activities.

Business objectives

The business objective is why we are working on a theme. Without this information, teams risk delivering features that do not enhance the product or add value to users. Additionally, the objective should help to influence the design team's solutions, as it serves as a hypothesis for the delivered solution, "We know we solved the need if: {business outcome} is achieved." The team's Product Manager is responsible for creating business objectives.

Requirements

Requirements are more granular aspects of a theme that help define the scope of the problem and solution area. Typically, requirements are derived from feature issues and research insights used to create the theme. Generally speaking, it is more common to see these items in themes in the (Now {Next:1-3 milestones}, or Next {Next:4-7}) buckets, as the problem areas have been researched, and the problems to solve are more evident than themes scheduled in the future. Requirements will take the form of: "The user needs to be able to {solution agnostic description of the need}."

Note: We are not designing a solution for a specific feature issue; instead, we are designing the entire theme. The individual feature issues within it will be addressed through a planning breakdown session when the UX Theme's vision design has been completed and is now ready to be built via MVC + Iterations.

Confidence

Confidence is the assessment of the product and design team's understanding of the problem and solution space the theme occupies, demonstrated through research or knowledge derived from users through other means. Use the table below to understand your confidence in the theme.

		High confidence		Medium confidence		Medium confidence		Low confidence	
	---		---		---		---		---
	The team understands both the main job and the small job(s) related to the problem area?								
Yes		Yes		No		No			
	Has the problem been validated through research or other means?								
Yes		No		Yes		No			

Timeframes

Themes should span multiple milestones, allowing designers to have the flexibility and freedom to explore and validate their solutions. However, this is a guideline, not a rule. To meet our

needs and work within the planning vocabulary of GitLab, we will define the timeframes as follows:

| Timeframe | Workflow | Design Priority | Research Priority | Theme Confidence | Theme Needs |
Research hand-off | ~ Design hand-off |
| --- | --- | --- | --- | --- | --- |
| Now: {Next 1-3 Milestones} | Workflow:design (Actively worked on) | Priority:1 | - | High |
Design & solution validation | Complete | Within 3 milestones |
| Next: {Next 4-7 Milestones} | Workflow:problem validation | Priority:2 | Priority:1 | High
or Medium | Problem validation research may be needed, Requirements needed| Within 3 milestones
| Within 7 milestones |
| Future: {Next 7-13 Milestones} | Workflow:problem validation backlog | Priority:3 |
Priority:2 | Medium or Low | Research is required to increase confidence and define the scope |
Within 7 milestones | Within 13 milestones |
| Future+: {Awaiting further demand} | Workflow:problem validation backlog | Priority:4 |
Priority:4 | Low | Research is required to increase confidence and define the scope | Within
the next 13 milestones | TBD |

These timeframes denote when work will take place and when work will be delivered. Think of this as design and research will be delivered within < timeframe > (e.g., design/research delivered in Now: {Next 1-3 Milestones}). In many cases, it will make sense for a lower confidence theme located in the Next or Future buckets to be worked on in parallel by the group's UX Researcher and/or the Product Manager to increase the confidence, allowing the theme to move up to the Now bucket for future design work. Just like design should be 2-3 milestones ahead of build, research should be 2-3 milestones ahead of design.

Consider this: If you only work on four themes a year and each gets broken down into three MVCs, that equates to delivering UX value to the user every milestone across twelve milestones.

Ownership

The Design DRI and respective Product Manager are the owners of themes in their group. However, in GitLab, we want to ensure themes are assigned to team members who are actively working on them. For example, a Product Designer and a UX Researcher, or a Product Manager and a UX Researcher may be assigned to a theme if the work demands it.

Working on themes (Designing Thematically)

Product Designers working on themes

Most of the work Product Designers do will be on themes in the (Now): {Next 1-3 milestone} bucket. These themes are comprised of high-confidence outcomes and validated needs: the problem is already well defined and researched, the JTBD, user persona, user needs/requirements, and business objectives are well understood, and themes, therefore, are ready for a design solution to be created.

The UX Theme issue is where all planning, discussion, and collaboration occurs. It is what the research and solutions are based on. The related issues contained within it are parts of the whole and may evolve or even get closed as more knowledge and understanding of the theme becomes clear. As work progresses on the theme, new issues may also need to be created per our

existing workflow processes. As these are based on the theme, they will be added or linked to the theme for tracking purposes. The most important aspect of working on themes is that research and design solutions are based on the theme first and any related MVC issues second. The intention is to work on the whole of the theme in a complete, holistic way as opposed to its individual-related issues. This process is about workflows vs. features and delivering quality and value to our users vs. an incomplete start of something that's viable but lacks value or usability.

As the design is completed (progressing from low-fidelity to high-fidelity), assets should be uploaded to the UX Theme issue, either in the description or in the design management tool for tracking/SSOT purposes. When the holistic design is complete, notify your counterparts that it is ready for planning breakdown following the Product Development Workflow guidelines.

Suggested workflow

1. Assess your theme. Do you have everything you need to generate design solution(s)?

- Refer to the Product design process: Define the opportunity to learn about everything you need to know to determine if you are ready to move into design.

- Once you've gathered all this information, ensure it is included in the theme's description as the SSOT. Use the UX Theme issue template for guidance.

1. Ideate and iterate Begin generating low-fidelity deliverables that incorporate all of the requirements of the theme, holistically addressing the JTBD, needs, and use cases.

- Create a flow diagram that accounts for all tasks related to the small job(s) you are addressing. Share this with your counterparts to ensure everyone is on the right page regarding the scope and requirements.

- Create low-fidelity wireframes that incorporate all of the requirements of the theme, holistically addressing the small job(s) while keeping the main JTBD in mind.

- Collaborate with your counterparts early and often. Adjust your designs after soliciting feedback from your counterparts and the UX team as needed.

1. Validate the workflow. Increase your confidence in your design direction with the solution validation method that best fits your project. It's always recommended that you validate your low-fidelity wireframe design. After all, this is the design you'll be working from in subsequent milestones, so it is best to ensure that it is usable and meets your user's goals and needs while in this low-fidelity state. Test it while it is cheap! Another added benefit to testing at this stage is that you are validating the entire workflow you are addressing rather than a smaller discrete action or capability. Following this approach increases the likelihood of receiving appropriate usability feedback on the tasks that make up the small job.

- Select a solution validation method and test your workflow using the small job(s) as the task users need to complete.

- Adjust your designs as necessary based on this user feedback solidifying your low-fidelity wireframe design direction.

1. Refine your concept. This step is like coloring in the lines of a coloring book, where the coloring book is the low-fidelity wireframe, and your mock-ups are the crayons that fill in all the details.

- Transition your wireframes to high-fidelity mock-ups. Determine which Pajamas components make the most sense for your solution.

- Define all of the micro-interactions, for example, tooltips, popovers, toasts, alerts, modals, and drawers.

- Define all of the edge cases, for example, error states, empty states, free vs. paid states, and states for users without permission.

- Write your micro-copy, and collaborate with your tech writing counterpart to ensure the copy meets our standards.
 - Consider accessibility guidelines.
 - Again, it is recommended that you validate your design with solution validation to ensure you haven't lost anything in the translation from your low-fidelity wireframe design to your high-fidelity mock-ups.
 - Adjust your designs as necessary based on this user feedback solidifying your design direction.
1. Hand-off. Work with your counterparts to break down your design into appropriate MVC(s).
 - Consider the value each MVC provides to the user and if it can stand alone without its subsequent MVCs in the product. If it cannot stand alone, discuss the possibility of a feature flag or a delayed release with your team.
 - Follow the rest of the Product Development Flow once you and your team have completed the planning breakdown process.

UX Research working on themes

Most of UX Researchers' work will be on the themes in the Next: {Next 4-7 milestones} bucket or (Future) Next: {7-13 milestones} bucket. Working ahead affords UX Research the time and space to design a study, recruit participants, execute the research, and summarize the results without compromising the methodology due to time constraints. Research and insight issues should be referenced in the UX Theme issue to maintain the SSOT.

Work with your UX Researcher during their research prioritization efforts by referencing UX Themes in the Next: {Next 4-7 milestones} bucket or Future: {Next 7-13 milestones} bucket. Your goal is to ensure that you are able to move themes from the Next and Future buckets to the Now bucket. This should only be done once you have gathered all of the information necessary to be ready for design, meaning you are now able to say that you have high confidence in this theme.

Revising and updating themes

Revising a theme can happen at any time. It is good practice to communicate when details change in theme issues so the team can remain informed without continuously monitoring the roadmap. For transparency, a comment should be added to the theme issue when changes are made that explains why the change was necessary.

Creating UX Themes

Creating UX Themes is a collaborative process between the Product Manager, Product Design Manager, Staff Product Designer (if applicable), and Product Designer that is done through the UX Theme workshop. It is important to highlight that this is a seasonal process, not something that needs to be done every day. After your initial theme creation workshop has been completed, all that remains is regular usage and maintenance of your existing themes. Below are some examples of when new UX Themes are created:

- The team does not have defined UX Themes for their stage:group.
- The Research team uncovers an unmet need in the JTBD that aligns with the goal and vision of the stage:group.
- The Product team identifies a new assumptive user need that aligns with the goal and vision of the stage:group.

- The Product team pivots to meet the needs of a different user.
- Community contributions have been submitted to your group.

UX Theme issues

Each UX Theme will have a dedicated issue and serve as the SSOT for all research and design activities related to that theme. UX theme issues should follow the established labeling conventions for the stage:group with the addition of the UX Theme label. UX theme issues must have a timeframe associated with them upon their creation and based on their confidence level. Doing so ensures all the teams (Product, Design, Research, Engineering) are aware of the state of the theme and the needs it may require to progress it. Use this UX Theme template to ensure you're including all of the needed pieces in order to be ready for designing a high confidence theme.

UX Theme organization

Existing product epics, category maturity, or vision epics can be used as containers for UX Theme issues, depending on how your product team organizes their work.

It is recommended to use GitLab boards to visualize your UX Themes in a roadmap format as they are in a place we are comfortable with, not to mention this adds another use case for dogfooding boards and provides the team feedback for potential improvements. The UX Roadmap board will be the primary way we consume and share the roadmap, while the individual themes will be the primary way we plan and work on the roadmap.

UX Theme workshop

Creating UX Themes cannot and should not be done in isolation. For themes to be successful, they require buy-in from team members who will be contributing to or consuming the content. It's best practice and highly recommended to conduct a workshop with the team, including the lead designer, PM, and Design Manager. Engineering counterparts may participate but it is not required. To help facilitate a workshop, a workshop guide has been created that leverages our asynchronous value requiring as little synchronous meeting time as possible; however, to ensure this is a collaborative effort, some synchronous components are necessary.

- UX Theme workshop guide issue
- UX Theme creation Figjam template

Example theme

View the example theme issue for a better understanding of how UX themes translate into GitLab.

Working on items other than UX Themes

UX Themes will not represent all the work that may be needed in a given milestone. Rather, it represents strategically aligned activities that deliver on the strategy of the stage:group. There will be instances where items unrelated to a UX Theme will still need to be worked on. Bugs, Deferred UX, or other usability issues and discrete urgent customer requests fall into this bucket. Themes can be thought of as the strategic design initiatives that are needed to be completed in order to achieve the overarching goal of your main JTBD for your stage:group.

While the other issues are for maintaining the experience pertaining to our standards.

SECTION: product/ux/product-design/ux-roadmaps/ux-theme-workshops/index.md

Overview

This document will serve as a helpful guide for navigating a team through the UX Theme workshop. Much like a user interview guide, the items detailed below are not concrete rules or step-by-step instructions; they are guidelines that allow for minor deviations in the process, which will happen as every team is different.

Preparing the workshop

1. Create an issue in the GitLab Design Project using the UX Theme Workshop Template.
1. Fill out the information in the issue template and assign it to yourself and the participants that will be joining you.
1. Send a two-hour meeting invite to the participants (Subject: UX Theme workshop for <stage:group>)
 1. Link to issue in the meeting invite
 1. Link to the homework section of the issue in the meeting invite.
 1. Change the due date to reflect the dates from the workshop issue.

Below is a template comment you can use for the meeting invite.

text

Hello! You are invited to participate in creating a UX Theme workshop for <Stage:group> .!

Session info

- Everyone: please review the information in (this issue), which will be our guide throughout the process.

Homework (Due <date> by EOD)

- <PM Name & Designer Name>: As the Product & Design DRIs, we need your help gathering a few links prior to the session. Please review the (Homework section) for more details.

Break --- (5 min)

Theme refinement (45 min)

Playback & wrap-up (5 min)

Note: The session may not take the entire time, though it is recommended to come prepared in the event it goes the entire 2 hours. Please no multitasking, be prepared to focus on the workshop for the entire duration of the session.

Once the Product Manager and Designer have supplied the required information move on to the next step. Note: You may have to remind the participants to supply the information if they have

yet to do so in a timely manner. The workshop cannot be conducted unless this information is provided.

Preparing the activities

The activities will take place entirely in FigJam. Only Step 1 - Warm-up: UX vision definition and Step 2 - Cluster inputs into theme bundles require setup before the workshop.

1. Use this FigJam template and move it into the team's or stage's room.
1. Change <stage:group> to the stage group the workshop is for.

Section 1 setup

Follow the links provided by the PM.

> · Tip: Not every direction page is consistent. You'll likely find a mishmash of some or all of these sections within a Stage Group or Category page. You may even see inconsistencies across categories within the same Stage Group. Do the best you can in gathering the most relevant goals for each.

1. Go to the Stage Group's Direction Page
1. Read the Overview Mission, Vision, Letter from the Editor, and Strategic Direction sections. Pull outlines that will be relevant to help align the other workshopers in crafting a UX vision and ultimately create the group's UX Themes for the year.
1. Copy and Paste the lines and edit them into coherent sentences and paragraphs in the Section & Stage Goals text block.

Move on to Category Goals:

1. Go to the Stage Group's Category page(s)
1. Read the Overview Mission, Vision, Letter from the editor, and Strategic Direction sections and pull out lines that you think will be relevant to help align the other workshopers in the task of crafting a UX vision and ultimately creating this UX Roadmap
1. Copy and Paste the lines and edit them into coherent sentences and paragraphs in the Category goals text block

When complete, the FigJam should look like this:

Section 2 setup

Follow the links provided by the PM for the relevant feature issues. Only copy issues with the UX label applied.

> · Tip: Keep the sticky notes in their respective color grouping unordered. Do not arrange them by any pre-existing method (existing epic, product roadmap, group: category, etc.) The goal is to break down our existing organizational method used in GitLab for this exercise.

>

> · Tip: Ensure participants have enough space below the sticky notes to create theme bundles.

At least ½ of the horizontal area should be blank.

1. Copy and paste each issue title into a sticky note on the FigJam board at the top of Section 2.
1. Change the color of the stickies to yellow following the key in FigJam.
1. Select all of the issues and arrange them into a grid.
1. Copy and paste any UX bug issues and change their color to match the key in FigJam.
1. Copy and paste Deferred UX issues and change their color to match the key in FigJam.
1. Arrange these stickies into a grid and place them adjacent to the feature stickies.

Next: Follow the links provided by the Design DRI for relevant insights and JTBD.

1. Copy and paste each actionable insight issue title into a sticky note. Change their color to match the key in FigJam.
1. Copy and paste each JTBD into a sticky note. Change their color to match the key in FigJam.
1. Arrange these stickies into a grid and place them adjacent to their respective issue types.

When complete, the FigJam should look like this:

Make the FigJam board available to team members

This handbook page has information on how to set the appropriate level of access for your FigJam boards.

Note: If a participant does not have a Figma license they will not be able to edit content on the FigJam unless the FigJam owner has set it to be an Open Session. Open sessions only last 24 hours. You will need to communicate this to your workshop participants and reset it as needed. You can reset the Open Session as many times as necessary.

Facilitating the Workshop

Introduction (5 minutes)

1. Set the scene and expectations

Welcome everyone to the workshop; introduce yourself and anyone acting as a co-facilitator. Here you should mention the roles and responsibilities of everyone on the call. Restate the purpose of the workshop as well as reinforce that this is collaborative.

"Hello <team>, I am <...> and I am joined by <...> and we are here to guide you through this workshop.

"The goal of today's workshop is to leave with a stronger sense of a UX direction, goals, vision, and a prioritized list of themes. For your group"

"<participant>, <participant>, <participant>, you will be collaborating on this together, while <facilitator>, <co-facilitator> are here to assist you if needed. We encourage you to think and talk out loud as you go through the exercises.

"This is a safe space and saying 'I don't know' is encouraged. That's why we are here, to define the known and identify the unknown."

2. Review the itinerary

Share your screen and walk through the itinerary in the workshop issue. When complete, stop sharing your screen allowing the participants to focus back on their screens of the FigJam board.

3. Step 1: Wrap-up the introduction

Before we get started, are there any questions?

Activity 1: Goal and Vision warm-up (10 minutes)

Ask everyone to open the FigJam file (share the link over the Zoom chat), and introduce the first exercise.

> This exercise is part warm-up, to get everyone talking and part exercise preparing everyone for UX Theme creation.

>

> Teams may struggle with this, but it is okay. All that is required is statements on sticky notes so they can complete the goal/vision statements after the workshop.

1. Set the scene for the activity

"Looking at the first exercise in the top left you will see the stage and category goal and direction information. This was copied from the direction pages and should be referenced for this exercise."

"Next you will see a set of prompts to use to help define the vision and goal statement, talking amongst yourselves, try to add statements that you can use to help in your definitions."

"This is going to be our reference point for this year and act as our north star when scoping our work. Let's take about 10 minutes to brainstorm. If you need more time then that is okay."

"Does that make sense, any questions?" okay, I will start the timer now."

> Try not to get too bogged down in this step. The goal is for the workshop participants to walk away with an understanding of the group's direction and goals for the year as this will be the anchor for the rest of the workshop steps. It's ok if it's not the most perfectly written statement.

.. In FigJam Start the timer for 10 minutes

2. Observe and keep participants on track

- Ensure participants are talking
- Ensure statements are being added to the stickies

.. Watch as statements are added and ask probing questions, "Why is that important, tell me more about.." etc.

3. Wrap-up the activity

At the end of the time, ask if the participants need more time.

If yes, add 5 more minutes but no more than that.

Based on the number of stickies generated, you'll get a sense that more time is needed. Because
t